

The Texas Cultural Micro-revolution

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September 29, 2026

Abstract

I wrote this article in the fall of 2025 after the firing of Professor McCoul and forced resignation of President Welsh. I attempted to have it published in the Houston and Austin newspapers, but was rejected. A year has passed since those events, but I think what I say is still relevant, if only for reflection. At the time I did not post it publicly because of my position within the Graduate and Professional Student government, and I believed I could affect change from within more effectively than from without. Whether that was true is not for me to decide; but I do admit a small degree of shame in not having the courage to say these words publicly at the time. But better late than never.

Well, my fellow Aggies, what a semester it's been. As a graduate student at A&M, it's been one of the more colorful semesters of my academic life. And we're not even to mid-terms! But still so much to talk about. So. Let's talk. I would like to begin by sharing the story of Professor Sun Peidong. Over five years ago, Sun was a professor at a prestigious Chinese school, Fudan University. She taught an extremely sensitive topic in China: the Cultural Revolution.

The Cultural Revolution was a movement beginning in the 1960s spearheaded by Mao Zedong. He encouraged youths—especially students—to root out any of the “old society” that wasn't in line with Mao's agenda. Targets included professors, staff, intellectuals, journalists, and scholars. Students would drag their professors out for “struggle sessions” where they harassed, assaulted, and even murdered their instructors for not conforming to Mao's version of culture. (For a harrowing dramatization of such a session, I recommend *Three Body Problem* by Cixin Liu.) Universities were shut down for nearly a decade; scholars estimate that nearly a generation of Chinese citizens went without an education. The current regime in China

is very sensitive, so you can imagine that the Cultural Revolution is an extraordinarily touchy topic. Professor Sun taught her students the history of this “revolution.” But she had to be careful: informants were everywhere. She kept her class sizes small and assigned mountains of homework to keep would-be snitches off the roll call. But it was all for naught.

Students ended up reporting her to the political authorities for “improper speech.” In China, educators are banned, by law, from discussing Western values and instead must adhere to the party ideology developed by Xi Jinping. Sun, on the other hand, encouraged her students to question the official, established cultural narrative and to draw their own conclusions. But this type of education is not allowed. Sun was told to change the way she teaches; the party secretary at the university told her not to talk to Western media. She has since left China. And she wasn’t the only one. A literature professor at Hubei University, Liang Yanping was fired for “incorrect speech” regarding Japan and Hong Kong. How fortunate we are to live in a place where such state-encouraged snitching, coercion, and retribution, does not take place in higher education.

Oh wait.

I need not elaborate on the circumstance to which I am referring. The removal of professor McCoul and Dean Mark Zoran, and what can only be assumed to be the forced resignation of President Welsh were not the result of a careful, thoughtful, fair, but unfortunate sequence of events. They were removed, brutally, for obviously political reasons. Professor McCoul was guilty of not following the state-approved cultural narrative; a student reported her via social media. Political officials caught wind, the higher ups demanded heads, and the political regime did the rest. Do we really need to speculate? Do we really think President Welsh was outraged at Dr. McCoul, that he would act with terrible speed and vengeance against her, her department chair, and the college dean? Or do we think he was told, in not so pleasant terms, to immediately end their careers, when he preferred to handle the situation calmly and amicably? It’s not clear when he realized his head was next. But it was, perhaps precisely because he wasn’t a zealous prosecutor.

Some may object: “Well Dr. McCoul was breaking the law by referring to topics of gender.” Maybe, I don’t know—I’m not an attorney. But would you say that Professor Sun’s fate was justified because she violated Chinese law? Do you believe China is tyrannical for ruthlessly punishing their academics for daring to teach a controversial subject but Texas is heroic for doing the same? Where are your priorities, where are your principles? A university is meant to be a forge of thought, a place where bold ideas—right or wrong,

insane or brilliant—are crafted, tested, reformed, and reshaped again and again. A man was recently gunned down by an assassin while practicing just that: welcoming open discussion, debating back and forth, and showing that honest, good-faith dialogue is the only way to win hearts and minds. To ban ideas doesn't mean you've beaten them; it means you don't have a strong argument against them. You haven't won anything.

So where does this leave us? Well, for the Chinese, the Cultural Revolution left thousands, even millions, dead and an entire generation ignorant. While it won't be that bad, it won't be good. We can only assume that Welsh's replacement will not be a leader of an educational institution. Sure, they may have the degrees and a CV to back it up, but their purpose will be purely political. Indeed, the interim president was a republican state senator, and his "ties to the Texas Legislature make him uniquely qualified to guide the university during this transitional period." Politics, not academics, is his qualification.

As for Texas at large, I won't burden you with the many warnings of a "brain drain." It's unsurprising that many educators and scholars are thinking of leaving and warning their peers to stay away. Now I find these warnings to be a tad inaccurate. To call it a "drain" gives it the impression that a plug has been pulled and the contents are gently leaving under the natural pull of gravity. But this description does not capture the abrasive forces at play. I find "lobotomy" to be far better: a tool is being forcibly inserted into a center of thought for the purposes of stopping "mental illness," i.e., thinking the wrong thoughts. I don't need to list the damages such an operation causes. There's a reason the practice was abandoned long ago.

Is there anything we can do? For students—and not to be cliché—the only way to protect liberty is to exercise it. Students in particular still have a degree of protection à la the First Amendment. Your voice may feel minor, a faint whisper against a howling storm. But for those who demand your silent obedience, a whisper of dissent is deafening. And you have allies: your professors may be muzzled, but they certainly will help where they can. So. Think for yourself. Take a lesson from Professor Sun, and ask the question those in power don't want asked. Question, challenge, debate, reconsider, and repeat. The grave will supply ample time for silence. For alumni, money is a voiceless megaphone. A&M boasts one of the largest alumni networks in the nation; that network funnels millions (if not billions) of dollars to the university. If you refuse to donate to the university, citing recent events, you will raise eyebrows and activate sweat glands. I already know alumni who are refusing to donate to their maroon alma mater. So, internally, students must assert their rights: say the things they don't want

others to hear. Remember, the emperor is naked, and the people need to know. Externally, alumni can leverage their check books. Texas A&M has a proud tradition of excellence, both academically and culturally. We can return to that tradition and restore the time-tested values that so many of us are proud. But we can't wait for those in power to give it back.